

■ By Sharda Ugra

A few years ago, Rahul Dravid had done a promo for a news channel at the end of which he had grinned engagingly, and said words to the effect: "It's amazing what you can get away with, when people think you're a nice guy." Think about it. What would have happened to Sourav Ganguly, had he quit the Indian captaincy without warning, notice or explanation with 15 days to go before the start of a series against Australia? Choose between condemnation, laceration and evisceration.

Dravid, India captain for just over two years, did exactly that but was spared a public roasting. Much of it was because of his image, which remained spotless after a decade in the game. The rest was due to the mystery that accompanied the decision of the studious Bangalorean to throw in the towel.

BCCI launched a multi-million dollar Indian Premier League on September 13 by lining up the biggest names in cricket, Dravid included, and a couple from the world game. Less than 24 hours later, Dravid left his team with-

With the end of cricket's brief Dravidian era, Team India is witness to not just a change of guard but a change of generation and shift in its territory



THE SUITABLE BOY

out a captain, without a head coach and without a clue as to why he had decided to abandon the ship after seeing off the worst of a storm that had dogged the second season of his captaincy.

With the end of cricket's brief Dravidian era, India has witnessed not just a change of guard but a change of generation and shift in its territory. Mahendra Singh Dhoni, wicket keeper and anarchist with the bat, will lead India in ODIs against Australia and Pakistan, the first Indian skipper to come wholly from outside Indian cricket's traditional strongholds. His ascent to the captaincy is representative of the growing spread of the game

to ignored corners of the country and the growing confidence of its citizens. Dhoni is new India on two legs. The son of a pump operator in a rsu behemoth in Ranchi, the 26-year-old is equally at home joking about the desserts they put out in the Lords' dining room and at heading out of his hometown Ranchi on one of his 10 high-speed motorbikes.

It is all very heady stuff for Dhoni, from small-town axeman to captain of India inside less than three years, the fastest ascent to the top since Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi's in 1962. Dhoni is captain not just because he is the most suitable candidate but he is, in fact, the only candidate for the job. If he wants

to understand just what awaits him on the hot seat, he just has to look across at Dravid. A man who is known for correctness in game and conduct stumbled in trying to bring an end to his stint as captain. After a bruising encounter with the demands of leading the Indian team, this most indefatigable of batsmen declared himself fatigued.

Along with feeling the stress and his own poor form in the last two Test series, there were reports of cold vibes between Dravid and the current chairman of selectors Dilip Vengsarkar, and BCCI's usual failures. When accepting the captaincy after the turkey of a World Cup campaign, Dravid had stated at a BCCI review meeting that he was taking up the job on the condition that a full-time media and administration managers would be appointed. But that didn't happen. In an interview just after he quit, Dravid defended his res-

Along with feeling the stress and his poor form in the last two Test series, there were reports of cold vibes between Rahul Dravid and Dilip Vengsarkar, and BCCI's usual failures.